In *India After Gandhi*, historian Ramachandra Guha suggests that the first election in 1952 was an ‘article of faith’ for our Constitution makers. The first election commissioner, Sukumar Sen, described it as the ‘biggest experiment in democracy in human history’. A Chennai editor was less kind: ‘a very large majority will exercise their votes for the first time; not many know what the vote is, why they should vote and for whom they should vote; no wonder the whole adventure is rated as the biggest gamble in history’.

Sixty-two years later, we can proudly say the faith has triumphed; the experiment has succeeded; the gamble was well worth it. The 2014 elections, in a sense, were a reaffirmation of the process that started in 1952. More than 550 million Indians voted in these elections, larger than the entire population of the world’s oldest democracy, the United States. I shall never forget what a Pakistani friend once told me. ‘In Pakistan, when we want to change the government, we bring in the army; in India, you just use the ballot box.’ Indeed, we do.

Each of the sixteen general elections in this country has been special, though some are more significant than others. The first election was obviously a landmark one—a leap in the dark for a country that many western commentators were convinced would rapidly disintegrate. Nineteen seventy-seven was a historic election as well—in the aftermath of the Emergency, it restored public confidence in democracy and was a resounding rejection of creeping dictatorship. I was just twelve years old at the time, but I do remember reading the bold headlines: ‘Indira Gandhi is defeated by the people of India’. I am sure it must have been a remarkable election to track as a journalist—just imagine profiling Raj Narain after he had defeated Indira.

I would rank 2014 in the same league as 1952 and 1977. Having had a privileged ringside view of Indian elections as a journalist since 1989, I do believe that the sixteenth general elections mark a tectonic shift in Indian politics. It has been, and I use the word judiciously, a political tsunami (or ‘tsuNamo’). It’s a term that was first used by the key BJP strategist Amit